

# After your gum graft

## RECOVERY GUIDE · SOFT TISSUE GRAFT

Keep this guide handy  
Call our office with any questions

A small piece of tissue was placed over your gum to build thicker, healthier gum around one or more teeth. The graft needs to form its own new blood supply from the tissue underneath — this happens over the first 2 weeks. During that window, the graft is fragile, and **anything that disturbs it can cause it to fail**. Most of your recovery is about leaving it alone.

| TODAY                                                  | DAYS 1–14                                                          | WEEKS 2–4                                                           | MONTHS 2–6                                    |
|--------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Rest. Ice. Cool, soft foods.<br>Don't touch the graft. | Graft forms new blood supply. No brushing or flossing at the site. | Tissue pinks up. Sutures dissolve. Gradually resume normal hygiene. | Full color and texture match your other gums. |

### Leave the graft alone

For the next 2 weeks, **do not pull your lip down to look at it, brush it, floss it, or touch it with your tongue**. This is the single most common reason grafts fail — patients keep checking on them. The sutures and the tissue seal are holding the graft in place while it grows new blood vessels. Even gentle pulling or lifting of the lip breaks that seal.

## 1 The first 24 hours

### BLEEDING

Some oozing from the graft or donor site is normal for a few hours. If bleeding restarts, apply a damp gauze or tea bag with *gentle* pressure (not biting) for 20–30 minutes. Keep your head elevated.

### ICE FOR SWELLING

- 20 minutes on, 20 minutes off over the outside of your cheek or lip for the first 24 hours
- Swelling is usually mild and peaks at 48–72 hours
- Bruising on the face is normal and can appear days later

### WHAT NOT TO DO

- ✗ Don't pull your lip or cheek to look at the site
- ✗ Don't rinse, swish, or spit for 24 hours
- ✗ Don't brush, floss, or use a water flosser near the graft
- ✗ Don't use straws for 24 hours
- ✗ Don't chew on the graft side
- ✗ Don't smoke or vape — this is one of the top reasons grafts fail

### IF TISSUE WAS TAKEN FROM THE ROOF OF YOUR MOUTH

#### Taking care of the palate (donor site)

Many patients find the palate actually feels more sore than the graft site itself — the tissue there is thin and we took a small piece of it. It will heal completely over 2–3 weeks.

- A small amount of bleeding from the palate is normal for the first day. Apply gentle pressure with gauze if needed.
- If you were given a **palatal stent or bandage**, wear it as directed — it protects the area while you eat.

- Avoid hot, spicy, acidic, or crunchy foods on the palate for 2 weeks.
- You may feel a raw, tender spot on the roof of your mouth — this will gradually close over.
- Don't probe the area with your tongue.

## Weeks one through four

### GUM GRAFT RECOVERY · CONTINUED

#### 2 Medications, rinsing & hygiene

Most gum graft patients need pain medication for only 2–4 days. A combination of **ibuprofen + acetaminophen** is usually more than enough — see your **Medication Guide** for dosing.

##### CHLORHEXIDINE RINSE (START TOMORROW)

Because you can't brush near the graft, a prescribed chlorhexidine rinse (Peridex, Paradex, Periogard) keeps the area clean. Use it **twice daily** for 2 weeks. Very important: **do not swish forcefully**. Let it pool in your mouth, tilt your head side to side gently, then let it fall out. Don't eat or drink for 30 minutes after.

##### BRUSHING & FLOSSING

- Brush the rest of your teeth normally starting the day after surgery
- **Do not brush the graft or the teeth right next to it for 2 weeks**
- Do not floss near the graft for 2–3 weeks
- After 2 weeks, use a *very soft* toothbrush with light pressure — we'll guide you at your follow-up
- No water flossers, electric toothbrushes, or whitening products near the site for at least a month

#### 3 Diet

Soft, cool foods for at least the first week. Don't chew directly on the graft side for **2 weeks**.

##### GOOD CHOICES

- ✓ Yogurt, cottage cheese, pudding
- ✓ Smoothies (spoon, no straw)
- ✓ Mashed potatoes, oatmeal
- ✓ Scrambled eggs, soft fish
- ✓ Lukewarm soup

##### AVOID

- ✗ Hard, crunchy, or sharp foods
- ✗ Hot temperatures (can restart bleeding)
- ✗ Spicy or acidic foods (especially on the palate)
- ✗ Seeds, nuts, popcorn, chips
- ✗ Chewing directly on the graft side
- ✗ Alcohol for at least 72 hours

#### 4 What's normal vs. what's not

##### NORMAL (EXPECTED)

- ✓ The graft looking **white, gray, or pale** — this is normal for 1–2 weeks, not a sign of failure

##### CALL OUR OFFICE

- ✗ The graft turns **dark purple, blue, or black**
- ✗ The graft falls off or comes loose

- ✓ Mild swelling peaking at 48–72h
- ✓ Bruising on the face that can appear days later
- ✓ Raw, tender feeling on the palate
- ✓ Sutures gradually dissolving or coming loose over 1–3 weeks
- ✓ Slight shrinkage of the graft as it heals (some is expected)
- ✓ Mild soreness that steadily improves

- ✗ Heavy bleeding from the palate that won't stop after 30 min of gentle pressure
- ✗ Severe pain on day 3–5 that medication doesn't help at all
- ✗ Pain, swelling, or bad taste that returns after you'd started to feel better
- ✗ Fever over 101°F
- ✗ A foul smell or pus from the graft area

**i About the color change.** In the first 1–2 weeks, the graft almost always looks white, gray, or pale — it hasn't built its blood supply yet. This is the #1 reason patients panic and call. It does *not* mean the graft has failed. By week 3, it starts looking pink, and by a few months it will match your other gums.

 **If a suture comes loose**, don't pull on it. Leave it alone — it'll fall out on its own or we'll remove it at your follow-up.

## 5 Other things that may help

- **No nicotine** — smoking and vaping dramatically raise the risk of graft failure. If you can stop for at least 3 weeks, your graft has the best chance.
- **Sleep with your head elevated** for the first 2–3 nights to reduce swelling.
- **Protein** — 80–100g daily supports tissue healing.
- **Bromelain** (500 mg, 3× daily, 5–7 days) — may reduce swelling. Skip if on blood thinners or with pineapple allergy.
- **Don't exercise hard** for 3–5 days — elevated blood pressure can restart bleeding.

### When to call us

- The graft turns dark purple, blue, or black
- The graft falls off or comes loose
- Severe pain on day 3–5 that your medication doesn't help at all
- Pain, swelling, or bad taste returning after you'd started to feel better
- Heavy bleeding from the palate that won't stop after 30 min of gentle pressure
- Fever over 101°F
- A foul smell or pus from the graft area

### URGENT — DON'T WAIT

- Difficulty breathing or swallowing
- Rapidly spreading swelling to your neck or around your eye

Call our office right away for the on-call provider. If you truly cannot breathe or swallow, call 911.

*Gum grafts are slow healers — the first 2 weeks require patience and a hands-off approach. The more you leave it alone, the better it will look in a few months.*